

Regulating school fee

AFFORDABLE and quality education for all — that's a key goal of the National Education Policy, 2020. A big **roadblock** on this **ambitious** path **is** the economic **exploitation** of parents by many private schools that are **solely** or primarily **driven** by the profit motive. The **lack** of adequate **checks and balances** **has** fuelled **rampant commercialisation** in the education sector. In a welcome move, the Delhi Cabinet has approved a Bill to regulate fee in all schools in the national capital, **prescribing** fines up to Rs 10 lakh for any hike without proper approval. The **Bill**, **likely** to be **tabled** in the Assembly soon, **proposes** the formation of committees at the school, district and state levels. These panels will examine fee **hike** proposals by school managements in a **transparent** and **time-bound** manner. The objective is to protect **hapless** parents from **arbitrary** decisions that **reek of sheer extortion** — a **take-it-or-leave-it scenario** in which the school authorities **hold all the aces**.

Several states, including Gujarat, Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu, **have** their own **legislation** to regulate the fee structure of schools. However, state governments have repeatedly found themselves **embroiled** in court battles over this matter. In 2021, the Supreme Court **upheld** the constitutional **validity** of the Rajasthan Schools (Regulation of Fees) Act, 2016, confirming the state's right to prevent **profiteering** in education. Recent **protests** by **aggrieved** parents **have** prompted the BJP government in Delhi to come up with a regulatory Bill.



The legislation has tried to **incorporate** clear-cut **enforcement** provisions so as to minimise disputes between educational institutions and governments. Private schools often justify fee hike on the **grounds** of providing better facilities to students and higher salaries to teachers. However, most of them are **reluctant** to disclose details of income and expenditure. Such **opacity** leaves parents **ill-informed** and makes them more **vulnerable** to being **milked dry**. It is hoped that **robust** legal **safeguards** will **deter** schools from treating education as a **cash cow**.

[Practice Exercise]

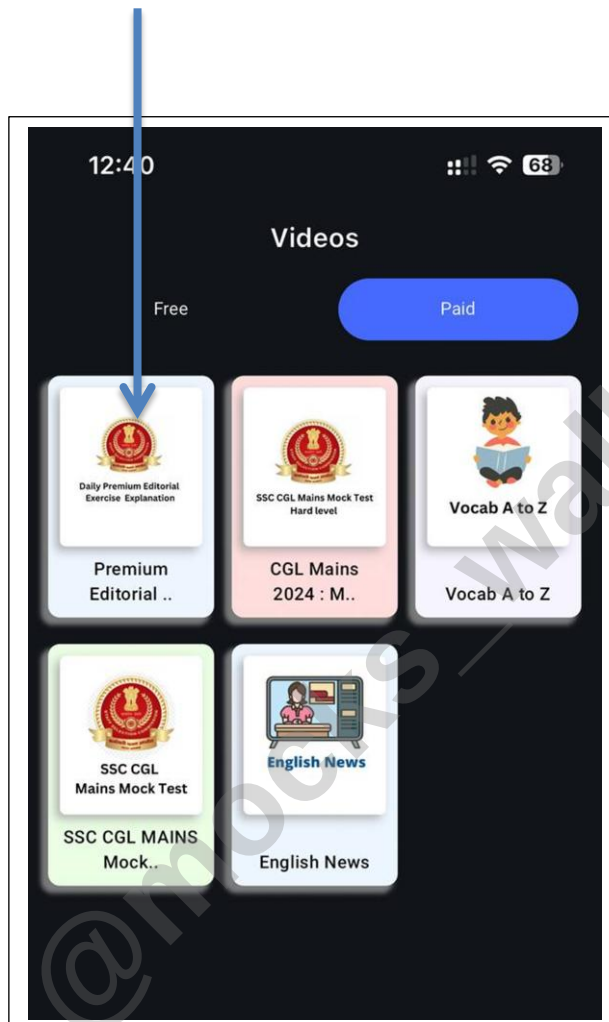
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject-verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Affordable** (adjective) – economical, reasonable, budget-friendly, inexpensive, low-cost सस्ती
2. **Roadblock** (noun) – obstacle, barrier, hindrance, hurdle, obstruction रुकावट
3. **Ambitious** (adjective) – aspirational, driven, determined, enterprising, bold महत्वाकांक्षी
4. **Exploitation** (noun) – misuse, abuse, manipulation, oppression, profiteering शोषण
5. **Solely** (adverb) – only, exclusively, entirely, wholly, purely केवल
6. **Drive** (verb) – motivate, push, compel, lead, stimulate प्रेरित करना
7. **Checks and balances** (noun) – counterbalancing influences by which an organization or system is regulated, typically those ensuring that political power is not concentrated in the hands of individuals or groups. नियंत्रण और संतुलन
8. **Fuel** (verb) – provoke, ignite, intensify, encourage, escalate बढ़ावा देना
9. **Rampant** (adjective) – widespread, uncontrolled, unrestrained, excessive, prevalent अनियंत्रित
10. **Commercialisation** (noun) – monetization, exploitation, marketization, commodification, business-orientation व्यवसायीकरण
11. **Prescribe** (verb) – stipulate, mandate, specify, dictate, impose निर्धारित करना
12. **Likely** (adjective) – probable, expected, possible, anticipated, potential संभावित
13. **Table** (verb) – present, propose, submit, introduce, bring forward प्रस्तुत करना
14. **Propose** (verb) – suggest, recommend, offer, advance, put forward प्रस्तावित करना
15. **Hike** (noun) – increase, rise, escalation, surge, boost वृद्धि
16. **Transparent** (adjective) – open, clear, honest, accountable, straightforward पारदर्शी
17. **Time-bound** (adjective) – deadline-based, scheduled, limited, fixed-time, constrained समय-सीमा वाला
18. **Hapless** (adjective) – unfortunate, unlucky, powerless, helpless, pitiable दुर्भाग्यपूर्ण
19. **Arbitrary** (adjective) – random, capricious, subjective, unjustified, despotic मनमाना
20. **Reek** (of) (verb) – smell strongly of, suggest, indicate, emit, radiate संकेत देना
21. **Sheer** (adjective) – absolute, complete, utter, pure, total पूरी तरह से
22. **Extortion** (noun) – blackmail, coercion, demand, exploitation, intimidation जबरन वसूली

23. **Take-it-or-leave-it** (adjective) – non-negotiable, fixed, rigid, inflexible, ultimatum-like जैसे हैं वैसे स्वीकार करें
24. **Scenario** (noun) – situation, condition, case, context, circumstance परिदृश्य
25. **Hold all the aces** (phrase) – be in control, have the upper hand, dominate, hold advantage, dictate terms पूरा नियंत्रण रखना
26. **Legislation** (noun) – law, act, statute, regulation, rule कानून
27. **Embroid** (verb) – involve, entangle, entrap, ensnare, implicate उलझाना
28. **Uphold** (verb) – confirm, support, validate, affirm, sustain समर्थन करना
29. **Validity** (noun) – legality, soundness, authenticity, legitimacy, truth वैधता
30. **Profiteering** (noun) – overcharging, exploitation, price gouging, greed-driven selling, excessive profit-making मुनाफाखोरी
31. **Aggrieved** (adjective) – distressed, upset, hurt, wronged, resentful पीड़ित
32. **Prompt** (verb) – cause, trigger, incite, lead to, provoke प्रेरित करना
33. **Incorporate** (verb) – include, integrate, combine, merge, embody शामिल करना
34. **Enforcement** (noun) – implementation, execution, application, imposition, carrying out प्रवर्तन
35. **Ground** (noun) – reason, basis, justification, rationale, cause आधार
36. **Reluctant** (adjective) – unwilling, hesitant, disinclined, resistant, averse अनिच्छुक
37. **Opacity** (noun) – lack of transparency, obscurity, vagueness, secrecy, murkiness अपारदर्शिता
38. **Ill-informed** (adjective) – uninformed, unaware, misinformed, ignorant, uneducated – गलत जानकारी वाला
39. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – exposed, weak, susceptible, helpless, unprotected कमजोर
40. **Milk dry** (phrase) – exploit fully, drain resources, take advantage, bleed financially, overcharge पूरी तरह दोहन करना
41. **Robust** (adjective) – strong, solid, firm, effective, resilient मजबूत
42. **Safeguard** (noun) – protection, precaution, shield, defense, security सुरक्षा उपाय
43. **Deter** (verb) – discourage, prevent, hinder, dissuade, obstruct रोकना
44. **A cash cow** (noun) – reliable source of income, profit-generator, moneymaker, lucrative entity, steady earner लाभ का स्थायी स्रोत

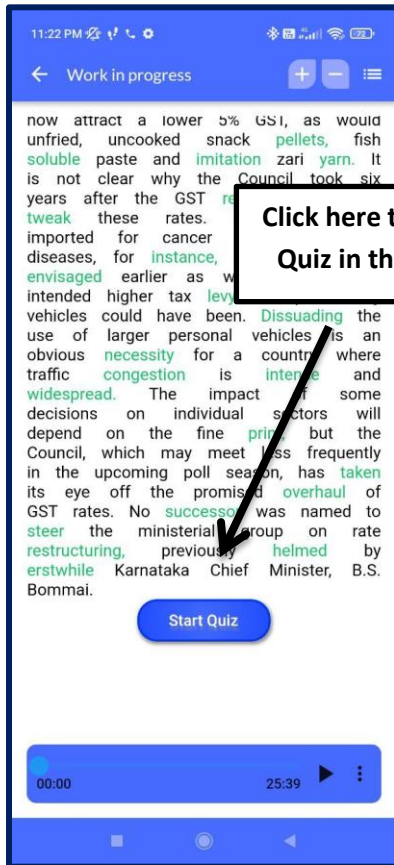
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



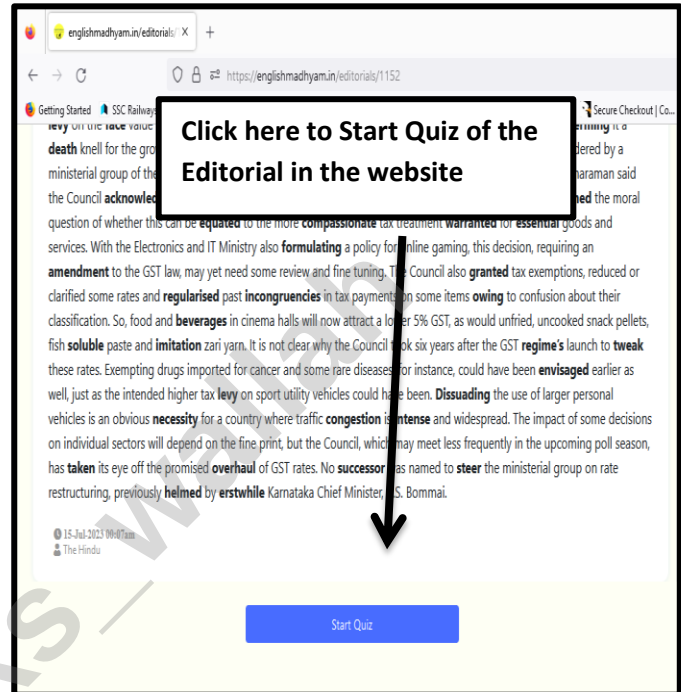
Summary of the Editorial

1. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 aims to provide affordable and quality education for all.
2. A major challenge to this goal is economic exploitation by profit-driven private schools.
3. Lack of effective regulation has led to widespread commercialisation in the education sector.
4. The Delhi Cabinet has approved a new Bill to regulate school fees across all schools in the national capital.
5. The Bill proposes fines up to ₹10 lakh for schools that increase fees without proper approval.
6. It aims to curb arbitrary and extortionist fee hikes by introducing a transparent regulatory process.
7. The legislation provides for the formation of committees at the school, district, and state levels to examine fee hike proposals.
8. These committees will function in a time-bound and transparent manner to protect parents' interests.
9. The move comes in response to frequent complaints and protests by parents over unjustified fee hikes.
10. Other states like Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Tamil Nadu already have similar fee regulation laws in place.
11. Courts have been frequently involved in these matters; notably, in 2021, the Supreme Court upheld Rajasthan's fee regulation law.
12. The Delhi BJP government has been prompted to act after rising public dissatisfaction.
13. The Bill includes clear enforcement provisions aimed at reducing legal conflicts between schools and government.
14. Private schools often claim fee hikes are necessary for better infrastructure and teacher salaries, but they rarely disclose financial details.
15. The hope is that strong legal safeguards will deter schools from treating education as a profit-making venture rather than a public good.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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